

Aangan's interiors (Left); The 10-course, set vegetarian menu weaves together a historical narrative with a multi-sensory journey that celebrates the region's royal legacy







The ten courses are divided in three sections, with each rooted in the legacies of its three guardians: Sridhara Narayana Munshi, the Maratha architect empahasising artistry and fortitude, whose belief in astrology and fortifications inspires the opening courses; Rameshwar Singh, the Maharaja of Darbhanga, a patron of art, stories, recipes and spiritual pursuits whose influence summons drama and devotion to the menu; and Arvind Kumar, the cultural visionary and sustainability advocate, immortalised through modern expressions of Banarasi tradition.

The amuse bouche is a savoury kalachakra-shaped achappam biscuit with a rich filling, paired with peas and curry leaf, as an ode to Sridhara Narayana Munshi's craze for constellations. The tender coconut ceviche, delicately infused with jasmine oil and lemon is artfully balanced with a cold leaf betel broth bringing alive sacred traditions. The hearty main course begins with a rich buttermilk curry infused with traditional spices and simmered with fresh vegetables is a soulful, comforting rendition that reflects the spiritual heritage and royal lineage of the Dharbhanga royal family.

The denouement of this historical pantomime celebrates the Kumar family in its final three courses, featuring refreshing elixirs and luscious desserts. Infused with the delicate notes of saffron layered with the fragrance of florals, the luscious Malliyo spins a cloudy foam of malai (cream), paired with kesar gel and a pistacio brittle and almond tuille. Of course, do ration your appetite to save space and calories for the decadent Rasmalai Tres Leche cake that preserves the grand Banarasi tradition with exquisite ease. The theatre of tradition culminates in a symbolic mithai box that pays tribute to all three guardians, cobbling together tradition and tastes. Of course, this is one dining experience that quickly transforms into a cultural memory, which simply humms on your tongue. They say, everyone wants a piece of heaven, but no one wants to die. Here's enjoying heaven, and living it up to tell the tale. Welcome to Benaras!

Where Aangan, BrijRama Palace, Darbhanga Ghat, Varanasi

Price ₹14,000 +++ (Cost of meal for two)